

The empirical recurrence for OEIS A214115, proved by transfer matrix

Adrian Perez Fontelles

Independent researcher

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Abstract

OEIS A214115 counts the proper colourings of a grid $4 \times (n+1)$, wrapped in the growing direction, with at most 4 colours and counted up to renaming the colours, and carries an empirical recurrence of order 26 contributed by R. H. Hardin. It is true, and it is decidable rather than empirical. Counting up to renaming is a fixed rational combination of ordinary colouring counts; each of those is a walk count; and because permuting the colours preserves everything in sight, the walk may be run on the colour-patterns rather than on the colourings, which is what brings the state count down to $S = 638$ and makes the exact residual test affordable.

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1 The conjecture

OEIS A214115 is “Number of 0..3 colorings of a $4X(n+1)$ array circular in the $n+1$ direction with new values 0..3 introduced in row major order.”. It has offset 1 and begins

172, 1331, 110985, 3008980, 136579852, 4797577911, 191154162535, 7146408189140, ...

The entry states, as a conjecture contributed by its author and never marked settled:

Empirical: $a(n) = 26*a(n-1) + 793*a(n-2) - 10672*a(n-3) - 111685*a(n-4) + 1555742*a(n-5) + 3279675*a(n-6) - 80896036*a(n-7) + 42501359*a(n-8) + 1864752866*a(n-9) - 2747661047*a(n-10) - 22752052704*a(n-11) + 41970382902*a(n-12) + 159827903260*a(n-13) - 310989873234*a(n-14) - 665904810616*a(n-15) + 1268829519909*a(n-16) + 1620764697790*a(n-17) - 2947553967077*a(n-18) - 2132419325552*a(n-19) + 3856072745271*a(n-20) + 1195236104310*a(n-21) - 2617797795489*a(n-22) + 77268263580*a(n-23) + 689877538245*a(n-24) - 233806181994*a(n-25) + 22293440379*a(n-26)$

As of the “Last modified” line on the live entry (Oct 03 2025 16:52:27, revision 8) this is still recorded as empirical, and nothing on the entry records it as proved.

2 What is being counted

A *colouring* here is proper: cells adjacent horizontally or vertically carry different values, and “circular in one direction” means the two ends of that direction are adjacent as well. The check that this is the right reading is the entry’s own first term for the one-row case: a cycle of W cells has $(i-1)^W + (-1)^W(i-1)$ proper colourings over i colours, which at $W = 6$, $i = 3$ is 66, and $66/3! = 11$ is what the corresponding entry of this family publishes.

The clause “new values 0..3 introduced in row major order” says the array is the canonical representative of its equality pattern, so what is counted is patterns, not arrays. Write N_j for

the number of admissible patterns using exactly j colours and L_i for the number of admissible colourings over an alphabet of i colours. A colouring over i colours is a pattern together with an injection of its colours into the alphabet, so

$$L_i = \sum_j N_j i(i-1) \cdots (i-j+1),$$

a triangular system with unit diagonal, hence invertible over $\mathbf{Q}$. The entry counts $a = N_1 + \cdots + N_4$, so

$$a = \sum_{i=1}^4 w_i L_i$$

for one fixed rational vector $w = \mathbf{1}^\top F^{-1}$, F the matrix of falling factorials. Being properly coloured is a statement about equalities alone, so it is invariant under permuting the colours and the reduction is legitimate.

3 Each L_i is a walk count

A column of the array is a proper colouring of the path P_4 and two consecutive columns must differ in every one of the 4 positions; the wrapping makes the last column adjacent to the first. A colouring of the array is therefore a CLOSED walk of $m = n+1$ steps in the digraph T_i whose vertices are the proper colourings of P_4 over i colours and whose edges join colourings differing everywhere, so

$$L_i(n) = \text{tr } T_i^m, \quad m = n+1.$$

A trace is not $\iota^\top M^m \tau$ for fixed vectors, and computing it as a sum over all starting vertices is far too expensive. Lemma 1 replaces it by a handful of walks with fixed ends.

Lemma 1. *Let G be a group acting on the vertex set of a digraph and preserving its edges, and let M be the adjacency matrix. Then $(M^m)_{ss} = (M^m)_{\sigma s, \sigma s}$ for every $\sigma \in G$, and hence*

$$\text{tr } M^m = \sum_{\text{orbits } O} |O| (M^m)_{s_O s_O},$$

one representative s_O per orbit. For T_i with $G = S_i$ permuting the colours, the orbits are the equality patterns and the orbit of a colouring using j colours has $i(i-1) \cdots (i-j+1)$ members.

Proof. σ permutes the vertices and carries walks to walks bijectively, so the closed walks of length m at s correspond to those at σs . Summing the diagonal over each orbit gives the displayed identity. Permuting colours preserves “differ in every position”, so S_i acts on the colourings of P_4 preserving T_i ; two colourings lie in one orbit exactly when they have the same equality pattern, and a pattern using j colours is realised in $i(i-1) \cdots (i-j+1)$ ways. $\square$

Lemma 2. *Let a group G act on the vertices of a digraph preserving its edges, and let v be constant on the G -orbits. Then Mv is constant on the G -orbits, and for a representative s of the orbit O ,*

$$(Mv)(O) = \sum_{O'} A_{OO'} v(O'), \quad A_{OO'} = \#\{t \in O' : s \rightarrow t\}.$$

So an iteration started at a G -invariant vector may be carried out on the orbits.

Proof. $\sigma \in G$ is an edge-preserving bijection, so it carries the out-neighbours of s onto those of σs ; with v constant on orbits, $(Mv)(s)$ and $(Mv)(\sigma s)$ are the same sum. The count $A_{OO'}$ is likewise independent of which representative of O is used. $\square$

- [3] N. Biggs, *Algebraic Graph Theory*, 2nd ed., Cambridge University Press, 1993. (Chromatic polynomials and transfer matrices.)
- [4] R. A. Horn and C. R. Johnson, *Matrix Analysis*, 2nd ed., Cambridge University Press, 2013.